

Document Differences Between States

User story

As a policy researcher, I want differences in CPS definitions and reporting practices documented so that the team can compare states fairly and explain when a comparison is limited.

Purpose and main conclusion

This document completes the four tasks for the user story: reviewing state CPS definitions, comparing reporting practices, creating a state differences table, and documenting comparability concerns. The main conclusion is that a shared label does not guarantee a shared measure. Before any state value enters a calculation, the team must verify its definition, numerator, denominator, population, reporting period, geography, missingness, and source evidence.

For the Fall 2026 pilot, Minnesota and Arizona provide a useful contrast. Minnesota uses more than one child protection response path, while the reviewed Arizona public materials describe reports that meet response criteria as investigations. The third pilot state should be added using the same table after Allen Huang and Snigdha Sahai confirm the edge case.

Task 1 Review State CPS Definitions

The working definitions below give the dashboard a consistent comparison vocabulary. They do not replace a state's legal definition. Each state-specific definition must still be recorded in the comparability note.

Term	Working comparison definition	Why state variation matters
Report	An allegation or concern received by a CPS intake or hotline channel about possible child maltreatment.	States differ in what meets the intake threshold, who has jurisdiction, and whether multiple allegations or children are counted as one report.
Screened in report	A report accepted for a CPS response after intake screening.	Screening rules and units of count can change the screened-in rate even when community conditions are similar.
Family assessment or alternative response	A response path focused on safety, risk, family strengths, needs, and services; a formal maltreatment finding may not be made.	A state with a large alternative-response pathway may report fewer investigations or findings unless both pathways are displayed.
Investigation	A formal CPS response used to assess safety and determine whether maltreatment occurred under the state standard.	Investigation scope, time limits, interview requirements, and evidentiary standards differ.
Substantiation or equivalent finding	A completed investigation finding that the applicable state evidentiary and legal standard for maltreatment has been met.	States use terms such as substantiated, founded, or indicated and may use different standards of proof.
Removal	A child's separation from the home and placement into out-of-home care through emergency or court-authorized action.	Some reports count removal events, some count unique children, and timing can be entry-date, point-in-time, or during-year.
Foster care population	Children in foster care for the stated reporting period and age range.	Point-in-time and served-during-year counts are not interchangeable; age cutoffs also matter.

Term	Working comparison definition	Why state variation matters
Recurrence	A later report, finding, or safety event within a defined follow-up period after an earlier CPS event.	The starting event, later event, follow-up window, and response pathways included must match.

Minnesota definition notes

- Minnesota defines a report of maltreatment as an oral or written report alleging that a child is being or has been maltreated.
- Minnesota may route accepted reports to Family Assessment, Family Investigation, or a noncaregiver human trafficking assessment. Family Assessment evaluates safety, future risk, strengths, and service needs but does not determine whether maltreatment occurred.
- Family Investigation is required for specified serious allegations and produces determinations about maltreatment and the need for child protective services.
- Minnesota law generally requires a family assessment or investigation to be concluded within 45 days of receipt of the report, subject to statutory conditions.

Arizona definition notes

- Arizona public guidance states that a report meeting the criteria for response is assigned to a DCS specialist for investigation.
- After investigation, Arizona uses substantiated and unsubstantiated findings. Public guidance also describes a proposed substantiated finding and an appeal process before final placement on the central registry in applicable cases.
- Because Arizona law and rules have changed the evidentiary standard for substantiation, the framework must record the rule version and effective date rather than assuming a historical series is definitionally stable.

Task 2 Compare State Reporting Practices

Practice area	Minnesota	Arizona	Comparison effect
Administration and geography	County and Tribal agencies operate within state oversight; public dashboard supports county or Tribal agency views.	State DCS publishes statewide reports and performance measures.	Do not compare county-level Minnesota results with statewide Arizona results.
Intake and screening	Reports are screened and assigned to the legally appropriate response path.	Reports meeting response criteria are assigned for investigation.	The screened-in denominator and response-path mix must be recorded.
Response pathways	Family Assessment and Family Investigation are distinct pathways; other specialized assessments also exist.	Reviewed public materials emphasize investigation. Any separate alternative-response program must be verified before coding.	Investigation counts alone may cover different shares of screened-in reports.
Findings	Family Assessment does not make a maltreatment determination; Family Investigation does.	Investigations end in substantiated or unsubstantiated findings, subject to applicable review and appeal.	A substantiation rate needs the same eligible case population in both states.

Practice area	Minnesota	Arizona	Comparison effect
Public reporting cadence	The child welfare dashboard is scheduled for monthly refresh and values may change with agency data entry and updates.	DCS describes consolidated monthly and semiannual reporting.	Record publication date, reporting period, and whether the value was later revised.
Public measures	Dashboard includes state and federal measures, agency details, trends, numerators, denominators, and performance standards.	Reports include hotline reports, investigations, substantiations, children in care, case management, permanency, and expenditures.	Similar topic areas may still use different formulas and time bases.
Disaggregation	County or Tribal agency filters are supported; racial, ethnic, and age views are being expanded.	Available disaggregation varies by report and table.	Absence of a public subgroup value is a data-availability issue, not a zero.
Version control	Dashboard points can change after refreshes.	Rules and findings procedures can change over time.	Store source date, extraction date, framework version, and definition-change flag.

Task 3 Create State Differences Table

This is the working table the team should complete for every pilot state and metric. The first two state columns summarize confirmed public information. The third-state column remains intentionally unfilled until the sponsor selects the edge case.

Difference	Minnesota	Arizona	Third pilot state
Primary CPS response model	Multiple paths, including Family Assessment and Family Investigation	Investigation for reports meeting response criteria in the reviewed public guidance	To be confirmed
Formal finding possible in every response path	No; Family Assessment does not make a maltreatment determination	A completed investigation can result in substantiated or unsubstantiated finding	To be confirmed
Local geographic reporting	County and Tribal agency views are available in the public dashboard	Verify the geographic detail available in the selected DCS report	To be confirmed
Public reporting cadence	Monthly dashboard refresh; annual reports also published	Monthly and semiannual reporting structure	To be confirmed
Known definition-change risk	Response-path and dashboard-measure definitions must be versioned	Substantiation rules and evidentiary standards have changed	To be confirmed
Direct-comparison readiness	Metric-by-metric review required	Metric-by-metric review required	Not yet reviewed

Task 4 Document Comparability Concerns

The EIM Metric Comparability schema requires one record per baseline field and scope. The following fields must be completed before a direct comparison:

Required field	What the team records
Metric definition	What the measure represents and the event or status being counted.

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Numerator definition	What is included in the top number of a rate or percentage.
Denominator definition	The population or case set against which the numerator is divided.
Population scope	Age range, eligibility group, response pathway, and other inclusion rules.
Reporting period	Calendar year, federal fiscal year, state fiscal year, point-in-time date, or rolling period.
Geography	State, county, Tribal agency, region, or another level.
Definition change flag	Whether the definition, law, system, or collection method changed during the series.
Data completeness	Years, jurisdictions, and required fields present, including known suppression or late reporting.
Availability status	Available, partially available, not routinely collected, not publicly available, not comparable, not scorable, unknown, or not yet reviewed.
Comparability status	Comparable, partially comparable, not comparable, or not yet reviewed.
Comparability note	Plain-language explanation of the important differences and permitted use.
Evidence confidence	High, moderate, low, not scorable, or not yet reviewed.
Framework version	The rubric version used for the review.
Unresolved question	The exact issue that needs sponsor, legal, data-owner, or methodology review.

Decision rules

1. Use Comparable only when definitions, numerators, denominators, population, period, and geography have been checked and match closely enough for a direct calculation.
2. Use Partially Comparable when the measure is still useful to display with a clear qualification but should not be directly calculated against another jurisdiction.
3. Use Not Comparable when differences are material. Keep the value visible for context, but exclude it from comparative calculations.
4. Use Data Not Available or the governed availability label for missing data. Never convert missing data to zero.
5. Use Not Scorable when the available evidence cannot support a defensible structural judgment. Not Scorable is not a failing score.
6. Use rates only when the same event, denominator, period, and population are represented. A rate per 1,000 does not fix a definition mismatch.
7. Treat outcome measures as signals for further review. Under the Fall 2026 scope, documented policy and implementation evidence determines the grade.

Questions to resolve with the sponsor

- Confirm the third pilot state and the reporting years to use across all three states.
- Confirm whether Arizona has a separate alternative-response pathway that must be represented in the comparison table.
- Confirm the minimum evidence-confidence level required for a public score.
- Confirm whether a definition change creates a series break or can be handled with a qualified trend.
- Confirm the preferred public label for states with major documented gaps.

Sources

Source note. The KARA/EIM files listed below are the controlling project sources. External government sources were used to clarify public definitions, reporting practices, and inclusive-language principles. State procedures can change, so dates and definitions should be rechecked before publication.

- KARA: State-by-State CPS Policy Comparison and Awards Project Scope and Sprint 0 Direction, September 17, 2026
- KARA EIM: Field Inventory and Data Tracking README, Metric Comparability, Pick List Reference, Observation Data Schema, Rubric Variable Map, and Validation Lists, updated through September 30, 2026
- Minnesota law: Minnesota Statutes chapter 260E, including sections 260E.03, 260E.17, and 260E.24 - [source link](#)
- Minnesota DCYF: Child Welfare Data Dashboard - [source link](#)
- Arizona DCS: Investigation outcome - [source link](#)
- Arizona DCS: Performance Measures - [source link](#)
- U.S. Children's Bureau: Child Maltreatment 2023 and NCANDS documentation - [source link](#)